

CHAPTER XXVIII

JUANA BETTER THAN NOTHING — THE LOST WOMAN OF SAN NICOLÁS

MY first visit to Santa Catalina was made, I think, in the hope of discovering a temple to the god Chinigchinich of the ancient Pimugnans, described by Torquemada, the padre of the Vizcaino expedition in 1602, but I hunted the deep cañons and the Vale of Avalon in vain. My first visit to San Nicolás was inspired by reading old Captain Nidever's account of the "lost woman" who, having been deserted, lived there alone for twenty years. She died back in the fifties; but Nidever's account of her hut and her life illumined the wind-swept island with a gleam of romance and pathos, to me at least, and I made three trips in all to it. But the winds, the human devastators — the curio-hunters, the otter-exterminators, and others, — and mostly the flying sand, had doubtless long ago wiped out the evidences of her occupation.

In the museum of the Vatican is exhibited, or was, a few years ago, a singular suit of pelican and gull skins about which a tale, true and affecting, has been woven. It was sent to Rome by one of the Mission Fathers on the Pacific Coast as being related to the attempts to Christianize the natives of that coast. According to Nidever, one of the old and respected sea captains of Santa Barbara, the Mexican Government

decided to remove the inhabitants of San Nicolás Island to the mainland, doubtless to better their condition, as they were being decimated by warlike tribes from the northwest, and to give them the consolation of religion.

The vessel sent out for them was a small schooner named the *Better Than Nothing*, under the command of Captain Sparks, an otter-hunter, who knew the Channel Islands well. The *Better Than Nothing* crew, and doubtless Mexican soldiers from the mission, rounded up the San Nicolános, and the vessel was about to sail, when a woman began to cry that she had left her child, a baby, ashore in the hurry. There were several versions of this. Some say that the skipper of the *Better Than Nothing* deliberately sailed off; others that it was blowing so hard that he was obliged to put out to sea. I can well understand this, as a worse place to land a boat, or to lie, does not exist than the spit at San Nicolás.

The poor woman protested that she must return, but her language possibly was not understood, and as the anchor was being lifted, and she realized that her infant was to be deserted, she drew back and they left without her. One story has it that she went aboard the vessel and later leaped overboard. Be this as it may, she was left — though she ran back, secured the child, and hurried down to the beach, crying, "*Manequauna*"; but they did not understand her, and sailed.

There is no doubt that Captain Sparks intended to return; but after the seven or eight San Nicolános had been landed at Santa Barbara, the schooner sailed for San Francisco and was lost. Time went by, months merged into years, and the lost woman of San Nicolás

became lost in reality. The story became a legend. The woman at first must have been nearly crazed at being deserted. After this came a revulsion of feeling, and she must have avoided the otter-hunters who went there, an easy matter to do on an island so large as San Nicolás. Some one must have seen the woman, or her house, as some time in 1850, or thereabouts, Padre Gonzales of the Mission of Santa Barbara requested Captain Nidever to go to the island and search for the woman.

Captain Nidever made three trips and searched the island from end to end, but failed to find the woman. On the third trip, still urged by the good padre, he took several Santa Barbareños, a number of Indians, and Mr. Charles Brown, or Carl Ditman, as he was also known. Some years ago Mr. D. W. Thompson, of Santa Barbara, wishing to obtain the exact facts in the case, visited Brown, then a very old man, with a stenographer and took down his statement.

Captain Nidever was positive that the woman was eluding them; so on the third trip he started at the southeast end, at the spit, and arranged his men in a line, several hundred feet apart, but all in speaking distance, and at the word of command they marched slowly forward scrutinizing every foot of the island, with the result that they suddenly came upon the hut of the woman. The statement of Brown is as follows:

"I went round the head of the island and found traces of the woman; went back and told the old gentleman that the woman was alive. He said it must be some of our Indians. I said, 'Our Indians have got bigger tracks than that.' He said, 'Well, if you think she is alive, let us hunt for her, and take all the men ashore.' We went up to the head of the island. There

was a kind of hill in the middle. I put my Indians a couple of hundred yards apart. I did not know what kind of woman she was, thought she might bite or scratch. We went from one side of the island to the other, and could not see the hill, and she was sitting on the side of the hill watching us. When we got across to the Indians, I said, 'There's nothing here, let's go back.' There was a basket and some feathers. She caught shags and had a coat made without sleeves, nicely covered with sealskin. I said to the Indians, 'You go to the hill and scatter the feathers and things in the basket, and if she is alive she will find them.' The same day we found them all gathered up and put in the basket."

On the following morning Brown persistently continued the hunt. Toiling up the hill, when he was about half-way up he caught sight of her. She was carrying something heavy, and rested at intervals as she ascended. Presently he came in sight of "three huts made out of whale bone." Perceiving that here was the woman of whom he was in search, he raised his gun with his hat on it as a signal to the Indians to join him hastily, as he did not know but she might "bite or scratch." He thus continues his narration:

"She had a brush fence, about two feet high, to break the wind, and right in front of me she sat facing me. The sun was coming in her face. She was skinning a seal before I came up to her. The dog, when he noticed me, began to growl. Thinking she might run I stepped round her, and she bowed as if she knew me before, and when the Indians came up they all kneeled."

The poor creature, when she saw beings of her own color and race, "held out some of her food" to them. She exhibited no fear, and at a sign went without



SAN NICOLÁS ISLAND

Home of the Lost Woman



ANACAPA ISLAND, THE EVER-CHANGING

demur with her captors, if such they can be called, though she afterwards gave them to understand that she would not have joined them if they had not found her. Brown and his followers carried away with them all her primitive belongings. "I took everything she had," he says, "and she took a big sea-head in her basket, and that was all."

The Nidever-Brown party remained at the island a month, and while they could not understand the woman (nor could the Indians), they obtained a fair idea of her life alone for twenty years or more on wind-swept San Nicolás. She had abundant food to eat in the abalones, fish, and all the shell fish eaten by natives. She built herself a house or home by standing whales' ribs in the sand, covering the top with brush. She was skilful in weaving from grass fibre, and made baskets from it. Of course she had a selection from thousands of mortars and pestles made by her people for thousands of years, which were strewn over the sands — and in diminished numbers are occasionally to be seen to-day. There were dogs on the island, and she had their companionship. She killed seals at night by stealing up to them and striking them with stones. From them she made sinew fish-lines, and from abalone shells she manufactured hooks after the fashion of her people; first forming a round piece of shell, boring a hole in it and breaking a piece out, leaving a hook. Certain roots found on the island constituted a food. She was skilful in catching birds; and doubtless in the long time she became hardened to the life and suspicious of the otter-hunters; hence she hid from them when they landed.

As soon as she was captured, she adapted herself

to their way of living and played about like a child. Brown says she was very tender-hearted and built a screen for a young otter so that the sun would not injure its eyes. She was alarmed at the rough weather on the way across the channel and tried to tell the sailors to appeal to the wind gods to reduce the sea, or something of the kind. Captain Brown said she recognized all the islands and had names for them.

When they landed at Santa Barbara she displayed much fear at men on horseback, and when she saw cattle she fell upon her knees. They assumed that she had been born on San Nicolás, and had never been away from the island, or even heard of the Spaniards. All her relatives had been taken to San Pedro, where all had pined away and died years before; hence she could not speak to any one, and while the padres of the mission summoned Indians from all the adjacent missions none could be found who could understand anything she said, and the only native word uttered by her that is remembered was "*mánequauna*"; what it meant no one could tell. An old woman who had been raised on one of the islands was at last found who could guess at the meaning of some of the strange words used by the woman; but nearly all her requests were made by signs. She was taken to the Mission of Santa Barbara and christened Juana Maria; to this the crew of the schooner added "Better Than Nothing," and by that name she was known.

Captain Nidever cared for her, and she appeared perfectly happy. She had a childlike nature, and spent much of her time going around in the evenings with Mexicans from house to house, dancing. So fond of this pastime was she that she danced, accord-

ing to Nidever, when any one went to see her. So much of a curiosity was the "Lost Woman" that Captain Nidever was offered a large sum to let her become part of a show. But the old Captain refused; he purposed that she should be happy the remainder of her life, and to his credit, be it said, she was. He fed and clothed her.

They estimated that she was about forty-five years of age when they found her. The new food she was obliged to eat at Santa Barbara did not agree with her, and in about six weeks she was taken sick, and died. Captain Nidever gave the padres her dresses of bird skins, her awls, wooden knife, lines, and grass bottles; the bird skin dresses were sent to the Pope with an account of her life.

The life of Alexander Selkirk was not so pathetic as that of this woman. Robinson Crusoe's island was rich in the bounties of nature, had trees and verdure; but twenty years on wind-swept San Nicolás takes one into the depths of tragedy.

On the east end of San Nicolás I found on my first visit a number of whale ribs thrust into the sand, which may have been left there by any of the collectors who visited the island since the time of Juana Maria. As I roamed along the shore, which was carved into extraordinary shapes by the wind, I could not divest my mind of the pathetic picture of this lone woman on San Nicolás; and as the wind howled and hissed through the rigging at night I could understand how the lone Basque herder believed that it was the protesting voices of the dead, of men murdered by warring men from the north, of women deserted and forlorn.

I believe that the power in man or woman to see the beautiful in all nature is one to be cultivated, as of profound importance; as, if one has this perceptive faculty keenly developed, it means happiness under all conditions, the ability to adapt oneself to the varying aspects of life. I have seen men who abhorred the very sight of the California Desert, whose beauties of color, tone, and tint deeply impress some men. One has but to read Van Dyke's "The Desert," to see a poet and artist's appreciation of the dreariest aspects of the world.

I fear that I have given an erroneous impression of San Nicolás, have not done it justice; for there are many attractions and natural beauties in this doomed and dying island, rent by the Furies, flagellated by the pebble-burdened wind. As I lay on deck one night, part of the anchor watch of my friend's yacht, where, owing to the menacing conditions, we all stood by — crew and guests — I could almost imagine I was listening to some vividly performed Wagnerian music. Over the highest mountains hovered a black genie, wings aspread, just as you have seen a hawk, conjuring the wind gods. The rivers of the sea were rushing by us, streaked with lambent flames. Every rope, hal-yard, and shroud hummed and moaned the melodies of despair, laughter, remorse, and death. The great seas that lashed the island on both sides met at our anchorage and fought their duels. The long, spectral, shroud-like spit reached out into the purple sea, like an insinuating hand of death; yet this was the home of Juana Maria Better Than Nothing for twenty years, and during all that time she fled from and avoided the sight of man. The very terrors, the tumultuous

furies of wave and wind and rock and hail, of inky fogs which beat about this island, the incontinent swirling spirits of the clouds — all are beautiful in the sense of Turner's *Slave Ship* and of the storm described by Ruskin.

It was low tide, and almost everywhere a black lava platform seemed to reach out into the wild sea, which came piling in with its wild white-maned horses riding on the crest, to be blown away or whisked off into the air. It seemed to me that I had never seen such high waves so near the dry land so beaten back. Brewster of San Buenaventura has made a photograph of this very spot.

Almost everywhere I found evidences of the people of the Lost Woman or perhaps of herself. I do not think I walked one hundred feet along that cave-infested and wind-gnawed shore without finding some object made by man. Here a toy of some kind, carved in stone; now again a few beads. Here some child had left a "pocket" of limpets, piled one within another, and mortars, pestles, stones, arrow-heads, flint chips, and out upon the sands of the west end tons of great red abalones — the assemblage of centuries — over two or three miles of sand-dunes in which were limpets, crabs, crayfish, shells, bones of animals, and shells of snails.

In some of the wrecked cañons the wind and sand had worked marvels, cutting out exquisite tracteries, lattices, serrations, open work; while on the sides were wonderful heads of strange beasts carved by the wind. Rising out of one of these weird cañons where nature had played havoc, I came upon a plain as level for several miles as a floor. In places it was covered with small red stones, over which the Lost Woman must

have walked many times, facing the hard west wind. Then I turned into a deep sandy cañon, in which myriads of slate-colored miniature mountains rose, with here and there patches of sand grasses in gold, yellow, and red — vivid pictures against the white sand that scurried along before every vagrant breeze. Here I imagined the Lost Woman might have found some of her material for making baskets. As I lay in the lee in the sun, it was not an unlovely prospect, if one can see beauty in the purest sand, in gold and green and red grasses, and in skies of eternal blue, across which are racing the genii of the fog in streamers and banners.

I found a deep cañon filled with siliceous stumps, which looked like trees where the wind had blown the sand away and left the ghost of a forest with phantom stone trees. I found a battle-ground, for so it appeared, of scores of skeletons, where perhaps the San Nicolános had gone down before the Russians or Inunits.

There was a doleful lack of verdure here. The ice plant, a few cacti, low wind-beaten buckthorn, and grasses that jangled in the wind and wrote their story on the sands. I floundered over sand-dunes, dropped down into deep cañons, discovered a curious natural stairway, which might have been carved by an artist, but nowhere was there any evidence of the Lost Woman's life or home, if I except the whale ribs near the point.

All my visits to San Nicolás were made in August and September. In February or March, after torrential rains, the island in parts shows not a little verdure, enough to support a large flock of sheep. Mrs. Blanche Trask, who has seen all these islands through a poet's eye, has collected about one hundred species of plants

here, many of which were new. She found on San Nicolás, at its best in March, but one shrub over seven feet high, and leptosynes five or six feet. On the edge of some of the cliffs my feet sank into the red and glistening ice plant which threatened to send one flying down the slopes. From the summit of one I watched myriads of shags coming in from the sea, forming and reforming in a vast convention until the flock made a single black shadow of huge size on the clear water. I saw few birds beyond ravens, ospreys, eagles, shags, cormorants, snipes, and the brown pelican, all of which were extremely tame, showing the ease with which the Lost Woman obtained the skins she used as protection against the wild wind of San Nicolás.

No one can visit this interesting island, which was an empire in its way before the arrival of Cabrillo, without being impressed with the fact that here lived a real Robinson Crusoe whose life history is a part of the pathetic history of the world.